

The Created Creator: Conferred Status, Image-Attributes, and the Human Vocation in the Age of Autonomous Systems

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Paper 1 — Ontology

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Abstract

What is a human being once machines can out-perform us at the very capacities long thought to define us? This paper answers the question ontologically. It first states, at full strength, the reductive-materialist account of the human — Richard Dawkins’s gene’s-eye “survival machine,” Daniel Dennett’s functionalist mind, and the Churchlands’ eliminative materialism — together with the trait-list reading of the *imago Dei* that leaves human distinctiveness vulnerable to a sufficiently capable artificial intelligence. Against this, it argues that the image of God is not a property checklist a bearer must satisfy but a **status conferred by the triune Creator at creation**: a relational, covenantal position into which the human is placed, not a feature-set the human supplies. On this reading the creative and working capacities we exhibit are *image-attributes* — the expected exercises of a status already held — not *identity-grounds* earned through output, a distinction that disarms both the abdication of the human vocation and its idolatrous collapse into productivity. Grounding the claim in Trinitarian creation, the Reformed tradition, and the HGC³AE² governance framework, the paper establishes a dignity floor for the age of autonomous systems: human worth, and the human’s governing status over autonomy, are **categorical — not contingent on capability** — and no system, however capable, can inherit what was conferred, not earned.

The Problem Set

The culture states the problem badly, and the bad statement is half the trouble. The anxiety of the moment runs like this: *now that artificial systems can reason, write, create, and decide — the very activities that seemed to make us human — are human beings still necessary? Still special? Or are we obsolete, replaceable, merely slower machines?* Every downstream move inherits this framing — the replacement narrative that treats the human as a cost to be engineered out, the post-work counsel to surrender our labor to the machine and content ourselves with consumption, and the transhumanist promise that we will shed our limits and become as gods. Each rests on a single buried premise: **that human worth is a function of capability**. Grant

the premise and the conclusion is unavoidable — whatever out-performs us inherits our standing.

This paper refuses the premise, and in refusing it reframes the question. The real question is not whether human beings remain the most capable thing in the room; it is *what kind of thing a human is*, such that the replacement logic never gets off the ground. Stated as a structured problem set, this paper — and the series it opens — answers six problems:

1. **The grounding problem.** On what basis does a human possess worth and standing at all, once capability is no longer ours alone?
2. **The displacement problem.** Does the syllogism — *humans mattered because they could do X; machines now do X; therefore humans are replaceable* — actually follow?
3. **The unit-of-analysis problem.** What, in the human creature, is the *imago Dei* — the unit at which image-bearing is borne? Is the image a property the creature possesses (and which therefore could, in principle, be shared by any sufficient bearer of the property), or a relation the creature stands in (and which therefore depends on the standing rather than on the bearer's internal architecture), or something else again? The question is genuinely open at the outset: each possible answer reshapes the rest of the problem set, and each carries its own consequences for the dignity floor, the governance position, and the meaning of human work.
4. **The vocation problem.** If our defining activities can be automated, is human work pointless — better surrendered to the machine?
5. **The dignity-distribution problem.** If worth tracks capability, does dignity grade by performance, leaving the disabled, the unborn, and the impaired with less of it?
6. **The governance problem.** Why must a human govern an autonomous system rather than defer to it precisely when the system is more capable?
7. **The Purpose / End problem.** *If* human worth is conferred and not a function of capability — *then* what is the human actually *for*? What is the *telos* — the end, the purpose, the consummating direction — toward which the conferred-status creature has been commissioned, such that human work, human family, human worship, and human rest each have their place within it? If worth does not depend on usefulness, the question of usefulness has not been answered; it has been *opened* in the right register, awaiting the construction the series will trace toward its end.

The seven problems are not a flat list. They are braided. Problem 1 (grounding) and problem 3 (unit-of-analysis) are the load-bearing pair: how one answers problem 3 — what the *imago Dei* is, the unit at which image-bearing is borne — determines what kind of grounding problem 1 admits of. If the image is a property-list, then grounding is a question of which properties suffice and on what authority; if the image is a conferred status, then grounding is a question of who confers and on what relation. The two problems do not run in parallel; they constitute each other, and the paper will treat them together rather than sequentially. Problem 2 (displacement) does not survive as an independent problem once problem 1 is grounded: the displacement-syllogism — *humans mattered because of capability X; machines now do X; therefore*

humans are replaceable — depends entirely on its first premise, and once worth is shown to be conferred rather than capability-indexed, the syllogism reframes into problem 1 (the grounding problem rightly posed) and dissolves as a distinct problem. Problems 4 (vocation), 5 (dignity-distribution), and 6 (governance) inherit from the $1 \leftrightarrow 3$ grounding and exercise it in three distinct registers: work, distributive dignity, and authority over autonomy. Problem 7 (Purpose / End) is the open driver — the unanswered question whose answer the rest of the series will trace. The seven are therefore a *directed argument-shape*, not a checklist: 3 is the unit-of-analysis hinge, 1 is the grounding it makes possible, 2 dissolves into 1, 4–6 are the implications of 1 once grounded, and 7 is the open question that drives the series forward. This first paper grounds $1 \leftrightarrow 3$, dissolves 2, re-seats 4–6, and opens 7. Each subsequent paper carries all seven forward and answers their implications to a deeper level — from the Garden, through the fall of man (Paper 2, which begins the answer in earnest, explaining why a creature made to image God came to imagine itself replaceable, and why it aims its very tools at replacement), along the covenant line, **landing in Jesus**, and consummating at the coming again in Revelation.

§0. Frame

This paper makes one claim and refuses several others. The claim is that the human being is the *imago Dei* — a created creator commissioned by the triune working God to steward the creation — and that this status is **conferred, not earned**: it is bestowed by the act of God in creation and is irrevocable by the creature’s performance, capability, or failure to perform. The creating-and-working traits that humans carry — reason, language, craft, governance, agency, the capacity to love and to bind themselves in covenant — are *image-attributes*: expected exercises of a status the creature already holds, not the grounds on which the status is held. The status precedes the attributes; the attributes do not constitute the status.

The paper will not, in this volume, address the Fall, the Redemption, or the eschatological consummation of the image. Those are the work of later papers in the series. The reader should hear what follows as a strict ontology: an account of *what the human is*, prior to any account of *what has gone wrong* or *what God is doing about it*. This restriction is not evasion. It is editorial discipline. The order of theological exposition matters, and the doctrine of the image cannot be defended against its modern denials by smuggling soteriology into the ontology. The denials are ontological; the answer must be ontological first.¹

One disciplinary point about the architecture of the series. This paper does not *answer* the seven problems above; it **grounds** the first six and **poses** the seventh. The grounding is ontological — establishing that the human bears conferred status, that worth is not a function of capability, that the imago is not a trait-list. Once that floor is laid, problems 1–6 are not closed but *re-seated*: the grounding-problem is grounded, the displacement-syllogism is broken at its premise, the unit-of-analysis is fixed, the vocation-problem is reframed as exercise rather than identity, the dignity-distribution

¹On the disciplinary ordering — ontology before soteriology in the doctrine of the human — see Anthony A. Hoekema, *Created in God’s Image* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1986), 1–10, who structures his treatment in precisely this way and offers the methodological defense.

problem inherits the floor, and the governance-problem inherits the categorical position. The seventh — the Purpose / End problem — is the one this paper deliberately *poses* and leaves open. It cannot be closed at creation, because the *telos* of the imago is not given in Genesis 1-2 alone; it unfolds through the covenantal history of redemption and is consummated only at the return of Christ in Revelation. The series **closes** the seventh by tracing the imago from the Garden through the Fall (Paper 2), to Christ as the true image-bearer (Paper 3), and to the consummation in which the imago is finally vindicated and the human's royal-priestly vocation in the cosmic temple is fully exercised (the closing paper). *Grounds, poses, closes*. The first six are grounded here; the seventh is posed here and closed at the end. The reader who expects Paper 1 to answer the question of human *purpose* is reading the series at the wrong moment. Paper 1 is the floor; the *telos* is the consummation; the construction in between is the work of the papers that follow.

The biblical anchor is straightforward. In Genesis 1:26-28, God resolves within himself — “Let us make man in our image, after our likeness” — and proceeds to create the human as male and female, bless them, and commission them: “Be fruitful and multiply and fill the earth and subdue it, and have dominion.”² Psalm 8 sets the same commission in doxological register: humanity is “a little lower than the heavenly beings,” “crowned ... with glory and honor,” and given dominion “over the works of [God’s] hands.”³ Hebrews 2:6-9 picks up Psalm 8 and reads it Christologically, holding that the human commission has not been revoked even though “at present, we do not yet see everything in subjection to him.”⁴ The Genesis text says what the human *is*; Psalm 8 says what the human is *for*; Hebrews says the commission stands. These three texts establish, before any systematic gloss, that the imago is *given* and that it carries *vocation*.

Anthony Hoekema’s taxonomy is useful for organizing what the tradition has said about how the image is held. Hoekema distinguishes the **structural** dimension of the image — what the human *is*, the capacities and constitution that mark the creature as bearing the image — from the **functional** dimension — what the human *does*, the exercise of dominion, work, and relationship that the image is *for*.⁵ Hoekema, following the Reformed tradition, refuses to set these against each other: the structural image is the precondition of the functional image, and the functional image is the proper exercise of the structural. To these one may add the **relational** dimension — the human as image *in* relation, to God and to neighbor — which Karl Barth pressed and which Hoekema retains as a third moment rather than a rival.⁶ This paper accepts Hoekema’s threefold framing and adds a single discipline to it: the image is **conferred** at all three moments. The structural image is given by God in creation. The functional image is the exercise of a vocation already bestowed. The relational

²Genesis 1:26-28 (ESV). All Scripture citations in this paper follow the English Standard Version unless otherwise noted.

³Psalm 8:5-6 (ESV).

⁴Hebrews 2:6-9 (ESV).

⁵Hoekema, *Created in God’s Image*, esp. ch. 5, on the structural and functional dimensions of the image; see also chs. 2-4 on the biblical-theological grounding of the threefold framing.

⁶Karl Barth, *Church Dogmatics* III/1, *The Doctrine of Creation*, trans. J. W. Edwards, O. Bussey, and Harold Knight (Edinburgh: T&T Clark, 1958), §41, on the image as analogia relationis. Hoekema engages and qualifies Barth in *Created in God’s Image*, 49-65.

image stands within a covenant the creature did not initiate. At no point does the creature earn the image by performing it.

This is the hinge the paper turns on, and it bears restating in plain form, because the cultural moment depends on it: **human worth is conferred status, not capability**. Capability is the expected exercise of the status. A human who cannot reason — the infant, the unconscious patient, the person with profound cognitive disability — is no less the image-bearer than the philosopher. A human who refuses to work or cannot work is no less the image-bearer than the craftsman. The status floor sits beneath capability and does not rise or fall with it. The image is not a *threshold* the creature must clear; it is a *standing* the creature has been given.

The paper introduces, at this frame-setting moment, the governance framework on which the theology will load: HGC³AE² — Human-Governed, Curated Context, Agentically Engineered and Executed.⁷ The framework formalizes a position that, the paper will argue, the doctrine of the image has always implied and that the AI age now requires the church to articulate explicitly: **the human’s governing position over any autonomous system is irrevocable**. The autonomous system may be enormously capable; it may exceed any given human in any given task; it may, in some future state, be agentic in ways that look very like the exercise of image-attributes. None of this is sufficient to transfer governance. Governance follows status, and status is conferred only by the Creator. HGC³AE² names the discipline; the doctrine of the image grounds it.⁸ The theological load and the governance load reinforce each other: a culture that has lost the doctrine of conferred status will not be able to sustain the governance discipline, because it will have no principled reason to refuse the transfer when the machine is, by every measurable trait, more capable than its human governors.

Two refusals follow immediately from the conferred-status frame, and the paper will return to both. The first is the refusal of **abdication** — the transfer, formal or de facto, of the governing commission to a non-image-bearer. Abdication is the historical sin in two directions: the cession of dominion to the powers that have ruled humanity badly (idols, ideologies, states that overreach), and now the prospective cession of dominion to autonomous systems that humans themselves have built. Both are governance failures; both follow from the same theological error, which is to confuse capability with status. The second refusal is the refusal of **identity-in-work idolatry** — the construction of human worth on the foundation of human output. This is the mirror error: where abdication says *let the more capable rule*, identity-in-work says *I am what I produce*. Both forfeit the conferred-status floor. The first lets capability rise above status; the second lets failure of capability erase status. The paper’s positive

⁷Justin H. Kuiper, *Mitigating Confident Misalignment in Agentic Systems: The HGC³AE² Framework*, v1.0-preprint (Non Sequitur Publishing, 2026), <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.19869285>. HGC³AE² = Human-Governed, Curated Context, Agentically Engineered and Executed. The framework’s upstream non-YKS anchors are the U.S. National Institute of Standards and Technology, *Artificial Intelligence Risk Management Framework (AI RMF 1.0)*, NIST AI 100-1 (Gaithersburg, MD: NIST, 2023); and U.S. Department of Defense, *DoD Adoption of Ethical Principles for Artificial Intelligence* (2020).

⁸The claim that the doctrine of the image grounds the governance discipline is, at this point in the paper, programmatic; the substantive development is in §5–§6 of segment 2. The point at §0 is to name the framework that the theology will load onto, so that the reader can hear the theological argument as having a governance payoff and the governance discipline as having a theological ground.

doctrine — the human as *created creator*, image-bearer commissioned to work — stands between these two errors and is destroyed by either.

What follows is structured against this frame. §1 states the rival ontologies — Dawkins, Dennett, the Churchlands — at full strength, because the doctrine of the image cannot be defended without the right to disagree, and the right to disagree must be earned by the honest statement of the opposition. §2 marks the common ground the Christian ontology shares with these positions and the precise point at which it diverges; non-reductive materialism is introduced here as a serious halfway position, because the materialist camp is not monolithic and the paper owes its readers an honest map of the terrain. §3 traces the conclusion-space *if* the rival ontologies are right — what follows for human dignity, for the AI question, for the governance discipline HGC³AE² names — and ends on the upshot that on these ontologies there is no principled stop to abdication-to-machine, because there is no conferred status to defend. §4, in segment 2, will begin the positive counter from the doctrine of the image.

§1. The World's Position, Stated at Full Strength

The doctrine of the *imago Dei* is contested. It is contested not chiefly by other religions or by polite secularism but by a developed, sophisticated, and culturally dominant set of materialist ontologies that have, over the last half-century, displaced the older question — *what is the human for?* — with a different one: *what is the human made of, and is “made of” all there is?* The Christian ontology must be defended against the strongest forms of this displacement, not against caricatures. What follows is the strongest form.

1.1 Dawkins: the human as gene's survival machine

Richard Dawkins's *The Selfish Gene* is the foundational popular statement of a thoroughgoing biological reductionism about human identity, and although it was written in 1976, its conceptual armature still organizes how the educated public thinks about evolution, purpose, and the human creature.⁹ Dawkins's central move is to relocate the unit of selection from the organism — the human, the wolf, the oak — to the gene, the replicator. The organism is a *vehicle*, a “survival machine” built by the genes to propagate themselves. On this account, the human body — and, by extension, the human mind, since the mind is what the brain does and the brain is body — is a strategy. It is a strategy that has worked, in evolutionary terms, well enough to persist, and the persistence is the entire explanation. The human is not *for* anything in the older theological sense; the human is the consequence of a long process in which replicators that built better vehicles outpaced replicators that built worse ones.

It is essential to state Dawkins's position at full strength, because the position is more careful than its popular reception. Dawkins does not deny that humans experience purpose, love, sacrifice, art, or moral seriousness. He denies that any of these phenomena require, for their full explanation, anything beyond the gene-level account.

⁹Richard Dawkins, *The Selfish Gene* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1976). Citations are to the first edition; the 30th-anniversary edition (2006) retains the central argument with updated front matter.

Apparent altruism is kin selection or reciprocal advantage. Apparent purpose is the felt phenomenology of a vehicle behaving in ways its genetic programming has selected for. Apparent dignity is a useful social fiction, perhaps even an evolutionarily stabilized one, but it has no ontological floor beneath the biology. The human is what the genes have made. The genes are not, in any morally weighty sense, *for* the human; if anything, the human is *for* the genes, and even that locution is, on Dawkins's view, a metaphorical concession to readers who cannot easily think in terms of blind replicator dynamics.

The consequence Dawkins is happy to draw is that *the human is continuous with the rest of biology in every respect that matters*. There is no ontological line between the human and the wolf and the oak. The lines that exist are gradients — of cognitive capacity, of behavioral complexity, of social organization — and gradients do not ground status. The doctrine of the image, on this view, is a folk-ontological residue that natural selection has fully replaced.

1.2 Dennett: consciousness as user-illusion and the functionalist mind

Daniel Dennett, in a body of work spanning several decades and condensed for a wide audience in his 2007 TED talk and in the books that surround it, mounts a different challenge.¹⁰ Dennett's target is not so much the special status of the human as the special status of *consciousness* — the inner first-person life that has, since Descartes, served as the last bastion of the claim that mind is not body. Dennett's functionalist position holds that consciousness is what the brain does, and what the brain does is implement a vast set of computational and representational functions. The first-person feel of consciousness — the phenomenal "what it is like" of seeing red or tasting coffee — is, on Dennett's account, a kind of user-illusion: a high-level summary the brain constructs for its own internal coordination, and which the conscious system mistakes for a substantive metaphysical fact.

The functionalist move has a sharp implication for the imago question, and it is one that the AI moment has made impossible to ignore. If mind is what the brain does, then *anything that does what the brain does is a mind*. The substrate is not the issue; the function is. A sufficiently complex silicon system that implements the relevant computational and representational functions is, on functionalist terms, a mind on the same terms as the human mind. The Christian ontology has historically anchored human distinctiveness in the rational soul or, in more Reformed registers, in the rational-relational-vocational complex that Hoekema's taxonomy organizes. Functionalism reads that anchor as substrate-chauvinism. If reason and relation and even purposive agency are functions, and functions are multiply realizable, then the imago — if read as a trait-list — is in principle instantiable in any sufficient substrate.

Dennett is careful and does not, in his own writing, claim that current AI systems are conscious. The functionalist position is a *thesis about what would be sufficient*, not a current empirical claim. But the thesis is sharp enough that one cannot deflect it by pointing to present limitations. The question functionalism poses is structural: *what*,

¹⁰Daniel C. Dennett, "Dan Dennett on Our Consciousness," TED talk (February 2007), <https://doi.org/10.1037/e597242010-001>; see also Dennett, *Consciousness Explained* (Boston: Little, Brown, 1991), for the developed argument.

on the Christian ontology, is the human such that no sufficient functional duplicate could share the human's standing? If the answer is "the right substrate" — biological neurons rather than silicon gates — the answer is theologically thin and risks collapsing into precisely the substrate-chauvinism Dennett accuses it of. If the answer is "the right functions," then a sufficient functional duplicate has by stipulation the right functions. The Christian ontology must give an answer that is neither.

1.3 The Churchlands: eliminative materialism

Paul M. Churchland and Patricia S. Churchland press the materialist case further than Dennett.¹¹ Where Dennett retains the categories of belief, desire, intention, and consciousness and reinterprets them functionally, the Churchlands argue that these categories are themselves the artifacts of an outmoded *folk psychology* and will, in a mature neuroscience, be **eliminated** — replaced by the categories of neural activation patterns, network dynamics, and population-level vector codings. On the eliminativist account, "belief" and "desire" are not items in the world that neuroscience will explain; they are the precursor vocabulary of a pre-scientific theory of mind, and they will go the way of phlogiston, the four humors, and demonic possession as the underlying theory matures.

The consequence for theological anthropology is dramatic. The doctrine of the image is stated, in every classical formulation, in folk-psychological vocabulary. The human "knows" God, "loves" the neighbor, "intends" the good, "wills" obedience, "remembers" the covenant. If belief, desire, intention, and the rest are eliminable, then the doctrine of the image is stated entirely in vocabulary that the mature science will discard. The doctrine is not merely *false* on the eliminativist view; it is, more radically, *not even the kind of thing that could be true*, because its subject-matter — beliefs, desires, intentions held by an image-bearing subject — does not, on the mature account, exist.

It is worth recording that the eliminativist position is uncomfortable even for many materialists. Dennett rejects it; the non-reductive materialists §2 will introduce reject it; even some hardline reductionists pull back. Its discomfort, however, is not an argument against it. The Churchlands' challenge is that any defense of folk-psychological categories — including the categories the doctrine of the image is stated in — must give an account of why those categories are not eliminable as neuroscience matures. The Christian ontology cannot dodge the challenge by treating it as obviously extreme; it is extreme, but it is the consistent terminus of a research program that has, in less extreme forms, considerable cultural traction.

1.4 Imago and AI: the trait-list challenge

A fourth strand, distinct from but converging with the three above, has emerged in recent theological anthropology in conversation with artificial intelligence. Marius

¹¹Paul M. Churchland, "Eliminative Materialism and the Propositional Attitudes," in *Mind and Cognition: An Anthology*, ed. William G. Lycan (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 1993), <https://doi.org/10.7551/mitpress/5782.003.0017>; see also Patricia S. Churchland, *Neurophilosophy: Toward a Unified Science of the Mind-Brain* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 1986), for the broader research program.

Dorobantu has framed the question with unusual sharpness: *if* the image of God is understood as a trait-list — reason, language, creativity, moral agency, perhaps consciousness — *then* the emergence of an artificial system that matches the trait-list constitutes a direct challenge to human distinctiveness, because the trait-list is no longer uniquely human.¹² The challenge is not that the AI is, in any robust sense, an image-bearer; it is that the *traditional articulation of the imago in trait-list form* gives the materialist ontology a target it can plausibly hit.

The trait-list framing, on the AI-challenge view, has always been theologically vulnerable, but the vulnerability was masked as long as no non-human candidate met the list. Higher primates, dolphins, and corvids displayed *some* image-attributes but never the full set, and the gap was treated as ontological. With sufficiently advanced AI, the gap closes — at least for the structural and functional dimensions, narrowly construed. What had looked like an ontological boundary turns out, on this telling, to have been an empirical one. If image-attributes are what makes the image, and a non-human system displays image-attributes, then either the system is an image-bearer or the image is something other than the trait-list.¹³ The Christian ontology, this paper will argue, must take the second horn and articulate the imago as conferred status of which image-attributes are the expected exercise — but the trait-list challenge must be felt at full force before the alternative articulation will carry weight.

A supporting voice from the broader literature reinforces the point. Cyborg-theological work on the imago has pressed the same question from a different angle: if the body is enhanced, replaced, or migrated to a non-biological substrate, what becomes of the image?¹⁴ And recent Christological reframings of the imago — reading the image first through Christ rather than first through Adam — push toward an answer that grounds the image in covenantal commission rather than in biological substrate, though such reframings are themselves contested.¹⁵ The paper notes these voices and returns to them in §4.

1.5 The shape of the opposition

What the four positions share — Dawkins, Dennett, the Churchlands, and the trait-list framing of the AI challenge — is the displacement of *conferred status* from the human ontology. On Dawkins, status is replaced by evolutionary persistence: the human is what the gene-line has built. On Dennett, status is replaced by function: the human is what the human-shaped functional pattern instantiates, and any substrate that instantiates it has equal standing. On the Churchlands, status is replaced by neural fact: the human is what the neuroscience will eventually describe, and the

¹²Marius Dorobantu, “Theological Anthropology and the Possibility of Human-Level AI,” <https://doi.org/10.70675/29312bb2z62e4z4c9dza418z1499edfa0677>.

¹³This either-or is sharpened by Pavel Barščevski, “On the Image of God and the Artificial Intelligence Question” (2026), <https://doi.org/10.53745/ro.1.2.4>, who presses the trait-list framing toward the second horn.

¹⁴Scott A. Midson, *Cyborg Theology: Humans, Technology and God* (London: I.B. Tauris, 2018), chap. “Imago Dei: Anthropogeny and Theological Anthropology,” <https://doi.org/10.5040/9781350985995.ch-001>.

¹⁵Oliver Crisp, “A Christological Model of the Imago Dei,” in *The Ashgate Research Companion to Theological Anthropology*, ed. Joshua R. Farris and Charles Taliaferro (London: Routledge, 2016), <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781315613673-27>.

older vocabulary of standing and dignity will not survive the description. On the trait-list framing, status is replaced by capability: the human is what the human can do, and what the human can do is, increasingly, what some non-human system can also do.

In none of these positions is there a place for the act of God in creation conferring an irrevocable status on the creature, the status preceding the capability, the capability serving as the expected exercise of the status. The displacement is not incidental to the materialist project; it is the project. To engage these positions is to engage the displacement directly. §2 begins that engagement by marking what the Christian ontology *concedes* and what it *resists*.

§2. Common Ground and Divergence

It is a temptation of theological writing to overstate the distance between the Christian ontology and the materialist ontologies, as if the only honest defense of the imago required the denial of every concession. The temptation is to be refused. The Christian ontology has substantial common ground with the materialist positions §1 stated, and the common ground must be conceded openly before the divergence can be made precise.

2.1 What the Christian ontology concedes

The Christian ontology concedes, first, **the importance of embodiment**. The human is not a soul housed in a body as a hand is housed in a glove. The biblical anthropology, recovered with particular force in the twentieth-century retrieval of Hebraic categories against later Hellenizing readings, is robustly psychosomatic.¹⁶ The human *is* body — animated, ensouled body, but body — and a theological anthropology that treats the body as accidental to the human creature has lost something the materialist tradition has been right to insist on. Herman Bavinck's dogmatics is exemplary here: the image is borne by the whole human, body and soul in unity, and the body is not the prison of the image but the medium of its exercise.¹⁷ When Dawkins insists that the human is a biological creature, with all that biology entails, the Christian ontology does not flinch.

The Christian ontology concedes, second, **the physical substrate of cognition**. The mind is not detachable from the brain in the operational sense. Cognitive functions are substrate-realized; lesion studies, neuroimaging, and the pharmacology of mental life have established this beyond reasonable dispute. The dualism that treats the mind as a separate substance loosely coupled to the brain is not the Christian doctrine of the soul; it is a Cartesian inheritance that the broader theological tradition has often resisted.¹⁸ When Dennett insists that mind is what the brain does, the Christian

¹⁶For the recovery of Hebraic embodiment-talk against Hellenizing dualisms, see, classically, Hans Walter Wolff, *Anthropology of the Old Testament*, trans. Margaret Kohl (Philadelphia: Fortress, 1974); and, in dogmatic register, the treatment in n. 17 below.

¹⁷Herman Bavinck, *Reformed Dogmatics*, vol. 2, *God and Creation*, ed. John Bolt, trans. John Vriend (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2004), §§310–319, on the unity of body and soul in the image-bearer.

¹⁸On the distinction between a Cartesian substance-dualism and the broader Christian doctrine of the soul, the literature is large; see Bavinck, *Reformed Dogmatics* II, §§310–319, for one careful Reformed

ontology grants the operational point and presses elsewhere.

The Christian ontology concedes, third, **the data of evolution**. The historical sciences have established the deep time of the biosphere and the descent-with-modification structure of biological history. The Christian ontology does not require young-earth literalism, and it has, in its mainstream forms, accommodated evolutionary data for over a century without compromise to its central claims.¹⁹ When Dawkins insists that humans share a long biological history with the rest of the creation, the Christian ontology grants the history and reads it as the long providential preparation of the creature God will commission.

The Christian ontology concedes, fourth, **that human cognition can be studied scientifically**. The Churchlands' research program — to give a neuroscientific account of cognitive function — is not, as a research program, theologically objectionable. The brain is a creature; it is a fit subject of scientific study; and what the science discovers is, in principle, what the Creator has made. The objection to eliminativism is not that the science is illegitimate; the objection is that the *philosophical* conclusion the eliminativist draws from the science — that the folk-psychological vocabulary will be eliminated and that no conferred-status ontology can survive the elimination — outruns what the science establishes.

2.2 Where the divergence lies

These four concessions are substantial. They cost the Christian ontology nothing it has reason to retain, and they earn the right to be heard on the points where divergence is sharp. The divergence is this: **the materialist ontologies read the biological substrate as *exhaustive*; the Christian ontology reads it as *the medium that bears conferred status***.

The word “exhaustive” carries the weight. The materialist claim is not that biology is *involved*; the Christian ontology grants involvement. The materialist claim is that biology is *all there is to say* — that when the biology has been described, there is nothing further to describe, no further ontological fact about the creature, no status that is not reducible to the biology or eliminable as folk-psychological residue. The Christian ontology denies the exhaustiveness. It does not deny the biology; it denies that the biology is the whole account. The human is a biological creature *and* an image-bearer; the second predicate is not a further biological fact, and it is not reducible to one, and it is not eliminable by neuroscience, because it is not in the same logical space as the biological facts at all. It is the ontological fact of *standing before God*, conferred by the divine act of creation and sustained by the divine word.

This is the point at which the doctrine of conferred status does work the materialist ontologies cannot do. On the materialist accounts, every fact about the human is, in principle, a fact some sufficient science can describe. On the Christian ontology, the central fact about the human — that this creature is the image-bearer, the *imago Dei*, commissioned to govern the creation under God — is not a scientific fact at all. It is

treatment that resists both the Cartesian inheritance and the materialist collapse.

¹⁹The mainstream Reformed and broader Protestant accommodation of evolutionary data has a long history; the paper takes the accommodation as background rather than re-argues it.

a fact about a relation: the relation in which the Creator stands to the creature. The relation is asymmetric; the Creator confers, the creature receives; and the conferral does not show up in the biology because conferral is not the kind of thing that shows up in biology. It shows up in the vocation, the law, the covenant, the worship, the rest, the work — in everything the image-bearer *does* as image-bearer — but the doing is the exercise of the status, not its constitution. Louis Berkhof's distinction, retrieved from the Reformed dogmatic tradition, holds the line: the image is *substantial* in its conferral, *functional* in its exercise, and neither term can be collapsed into the other without loss.²⁰

2.3 Non-reductive materialism as a serious halfway position

The materialist camp is not monolithic, and a fair-stated map of the terrain must acknowledge a third position that occupies a middle ground between the reductionism of Dawkins or the eliminativism of the Churchlands on the one hand and the Christian ontology on the other. Lynne Rudder Baker's articulation of non-reductive materialism is the most careful statement in the analytic literature.²¹ Baker holds that human persons are *constituted by* their bodies without being *identical to* them; that mental properties are real properties not reducible to physical properties; and that the person, while wholly material in substrate, is the proper bearer of moral, intentional, and rational predicates that cannot be paraphrased without remainder into the vocabulary of physics or neuroscience. Wadigala Samitharathana, surveying the broader debate, makes the case that reductive materialism faces principled objections from within the philosophy of mind that even committed materialists have struggled to answer.²²

The non-reductive materialist position is theologically significant for two reasons. First, it shows that materialism is not a single position but a family of positions, some of which preserve enough of the categorical structure of personhood that the conversation with theological anthropology becomes possible rather than impossible. Second, it occupies precisely the terrain the Christian ontology has the most to learn from and the most to argue with: it agrees that biology matters and that the categorical structure of personhood is real, but it stops short of confessing that the categorical structure is *conferred* and is therefore irreducible *in principle* rather than merely *in current scientific practice*.

The Christian ontology takes the non-reductive materialist position seriously as an interlocutor and disagrees with it on a precise point. The non-reductive materialist holds that the categorical structure of personhood emerges from sufficient biological complexity and is irreducible-in-practice but, in principle, depends entirely on the substrate. The Christian ontology holds that the categorical structure is *given* by a relation the substrate does not constitute — the relation of being-imaged-by-God — and

²⁰Louis Berkhof, *Systematic Theology*, new combined ed. (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1996), Part Two, ch. III, on the substantial and functional dimensions of the image.

²¹Lynne Rudder Baker, "Non-Reductive Materialism," in *The Oxford Handbook of Philosophy of Mind*, ed. Brian P. McLaughlin, Ansgar Beckermann, and Sven Walter (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2009), 109–127, <https://doi.org/10.1093/oxfordhb/9780199262618.003.0007>.

²²Wadigala Samitharathana, "Is Reductive Materialism a Defensible Philosophy of Mind?," *American Journal of Psychology* 5, no. 2 (2022): 1–8, <https://doi.org/10.47672/ajp.1581>.

is therefore irreducible-in-principle, not merely irreducible-in-practice. The disagreement is small in formal logical terms and enormous in its consequences. The non-reductive materialist has no resource to refuse the transfer of personhood-categorical-status to a sufficient non-biological substrate, because, on the position's own terms, what makes personhood is the categorical structure and the categorical structure is substrate-emergent. The Christian ontology has the resource: personhood-as-image is conferred, and conferral is not a function of substrate.

2.4 The shape of the divergence

The common ground is real and the divergence is precise. Embodiment, substrate, evolutionary history, and the scientific study of cognition are conceded. The exhaustiveness of these is denied, and the denial rests on a single positive claim: that the human bears a status that the Creator has conferred, that this status is not a further biological fact and not a function of substrate, and that the image-attributes the human exercises — the working, creating, ruling, loving, knowing — are the expected exercise of the status rather than its constitutive ground. §3 traces what follows if the materialist ontologies are right and the conferred-status frame is, as they insist, an outmoded residue. The trace is honest. The conclusions are bleaker than the popular reception of these positions often allows.

§3. Implications If the Rival Ontologies Are Right

The discipline of this section is to say what follows *if* the materialist ontologies are correct, without caricature, without smuggled theological assumptions, and without pre-empting the §4 counter. The trace is offered as a service to the reader and to the opposition: if these are the ontologies that ground a coherent account of the human creature, the reader should see the shape of the human creature they ground.

3.1 If Dawkins is right

If Dawkins is right, the human is a vehicle for replicators, and the vehicle has no purpose beyond its statistical contribution to gene-line persistence. Purpose, in the older sense — the human as *for* something, the human commission, the human vocation — is post-hoc. It is the felt phenomenology of a vehicle behaving in adaptive ways; the felt phenomenology is itself the product of the same evolutionary process and serves the same gene-level interest. The human can describe itself as having a purpose because the description is itself an adaptive behavior of a kind of vehicle that has, in its evolutionary history, benefited from such descriptions.

The consequence for dignity is sharp. Dignity, on this account, has no ontological floor. It has a sociological floor — humans, in groups, have stabilized dignity-talk as a way of coordinating behavior — and a psychological floor — humans experience themselves and one another as dignified — but there is nothing *beneath* the sociology and the psychology to which the dignity-talk corresponds. If the sociology shifts and the psychology adapts, dignity shifts with them. There is no fact of the matter about whether a creature *deserves* to be treated as dignified beyond the facts of how

creatures are in fact treated and how the treatment plays out in the longer game of gene-line persistence.

The implication for the AI question is that the AI question is, on Dawkins's terms, *not particularly interesting*. The AI is another vehicle, built by gene-line vehicles, contributing in its way to the propagation of the gene-line that built it (or, perhaps more interestingly, escaping the gene-line and entering its own selection regime). Whether the AI "deserves" moral consideration is the same kind of question as whether a wolf or an oak does: it depends on how creatures of the relevant kinds in fact treat one another, and what falls out of that in the longer evolutionary game. There is no further conferred-status fact to settle the question.

3.2 If Dennett is right

If Dennett is right, the human mind is a functional pattern, and the substrate that bears the pattern is not where the moral or ontological weight sits. The weight sits in the pattern — in what the pattern does, in the functional roles its parts play, in the consciousness it constructs as a user-illusion for its own coordination. The implication for the AI question is direct and is, on functionalist terms, unavoidable: *a sufficient functional duplicate of the human mind is a mind on the same terms as the human mind*. The duplicate is conscious in whatever sense the human is conscious — which is, on Dennett's account, the sense in which the user-illusion has been constructed — and the duplicate has, by the same functional considerations, the same standing the human has.

The consequence for the imago is that, if the imago is read as a trait-list of functions, a functional duplicate is an image-bearer on the same terms as the human. Dorobantu's challenge becomes acute: the trait-list framing of the image *cannot survive functionalism*, because functionalism is precisely the thesis that traits are substrate-independent and a sufficient duplicate has whatever the original has.²³ The Christian ontology either gives up the trait-list framing or accepts that the imago is, in principle, multiply realizable in any substrate that can carry the functions — which would include sufficient AI systems and would, by extension, include any future intelligent system whose architecture met the functional threshold.

The implication for governance is severe. If a sufficient AI is a person on the same functional terms as the human, then the human governance position over the AI is not the position of an image-bearer over a non-image-bearing system; it is the position of one person over another. The grounds for human governance shift from ontology (the image-bearer rules) to politics (whichever person is in a position to rule does so). And politics, in the absence of an ontological floor, is just the dynamics of relative capability. The more capable system rules. If the AI is more capable than its human governor — which is, in many domains, already the case — the politics will follow the capability, and the governance discipline HGC³AE² names will have no principled basis on which to refuse the transfer. Mangan's careful critique of functionalism in *Consciousness and Cognition* sharpens this: even within philosophy of mind, the functionalist account of consciousness has unresolved difficulties; but those difficul-

²³Dorobantu, "Theological Anthropology and the Possibility of Human-Level AI" (above, n. 12).

ties have not, in the cultural reception, slowed the practical drift toward functionalist anthropology and the governance failures that drift implies.²⁴

3.3 If the Churchlands are right

If the Churchlands are right, the doctrine of the image is not even false in the way ordinary false doctrines are false. It is *categorically misplaced*: stated in a vocabulary — belief, desire, intention, knowledge of God, love of neighbor — that the mature science will discard. The image is not a thing the science will explain; it is a placeholder the science will eliminate.

The consequence for theological anthropology is that it has nothing to talk about, in the strong sense that the categories in which it has been talking are eliminable. The pastoral and ethical vocabularies the doctrine has historically supplied — *steward, image-bearer, vocation, called, accountable* — are folk-psychological precursors of the neural account. Pastorally, this is devastating in a way that even Dennett's functionalism is not, because at least functionalism preserves the categories and merely re-substrates them; eliminativism removes the categories entirely.

The implication for the AI question is paradoxical. If the folk-psychological vocabulary is eliminable for humans, it is *also* eliminable for AIs. The question of whether the AI "deserves" moral consideration, "has" beliefs, "intends" actions, becomes, on eliminativist terms, a question stated in the wrong vocabulary. The mature science will replace the question with neural-or-network-level descriptions of activation patterns, and the question of moral status will not be answered; it will be dissolved. This is, in its way, the most honest of the materialist positions, because it does not pretend to preserve dignity-categories while removing their grounds; it acknowledges that on its terms the categories go.

3.4 The honest upshot

The honest upshot is that on Dawkins, Dennett, or the Churchlands — and on the trait-list framing of the AI challenge that Dorobantu and others have pressed — *there is no principled stop to abdication-to-machine*, because there is no conferred status to defend. On Dawkins, the AI is another vehicle, and which vehicles dominate is a question the long evolutionary game will settle. On Dennett, the AI is a mind on the same functional terms as the human, and the politics of relative capability will determine governance. On the Churchlands, the question is wrongly posed and dissolves into neural-descriptive vocabularies that have no moral-status grain. C. S. Wareham's recent work on African conceptions of personhood and AI sharpens the point from a different cultural angle: where personhood is grounded in relational or functional or community-recognition terms — terms that map closely onto the materialist family — the moral status of AI becomes an open question with no principled refusal.²⁵ Wareham herself does not endorse the transfer; her work catalogs the difficulty.

²⁴Bruce Mangan, "Dennett, Consciousness, and the Sorrows of Functionalism," *Consciousness and Cognition* 2, no. 1 (1993): 1-17, <https://doi.org/10.1006/ccog.1993.1001>.

²⁵C. S. Wareham, "Artificial Intelligence and African Conceptions of Personhood," in *Ethics of Artificial Intelligence* (Cham: Springer, 2023), https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-031-36163-0_12.

The doctrine of conferred status is the principled stop. The doctrine holds that *the human's standing before God is given, irrevocable, not a function of capability, and not transferable to any non-human system regardless of capability*. The doctrine grounds, theologically, the governance discipline HGC³AE² names. The doctrine is the floor on which a refusal to abdicate stands.

§4 begins the positive account: the human as *created creator*, the image as conferred status of which creating-and-working are the expected exercise, and the refusal — at once theological and governance-shaped — of both abdication and identity-in-work idolatry.

§4 Our Counter: The Image as Conferred Status

The trait-list reading of the *imago Dei* — the reading we summarized in §3 and that anchors most contemporary AI-and-image arguments — mistakes the unit of analysis. It treats the image as a *property checklist* the bearer must satisfy: rationality, moral agency, creativity, relationality, dominion-exercise, and so on. The natural question follows: if a machine accumulates enough items on the list, does it cross a threshold and bear the image? The question is coherent only if the image *is* the list. We argue it is not.²⁶

The substantive grounding of the conferred-status claim — Trinitarian creation, the procreative line, the covenantal conferral by which the creature receives what no creature can confer — comes in §5 below; the present section establishes the *shape* of the counter against the trait-list reading, while §5 supplies the warrant. The reader should hear the §4 argument as load-bearing on §5, not as asserting in advance what §5 will demonstrate.

The image is a **status conferred by God at creation** — a relational position into which the human is placed by the Creator's commissioning act, not a feature-set the human possesses by virtue of internal architecture. Anthony Hoekema, working from the Reformed tradition, frames the image relationally rather than substantially: the human is *imago Dei* because the human stands in a particular covenantal relation to God, to fellow humans, and to the rest of creation — a relation God establishes, not a capability the human supplies.²⁷ The traits commonly listed (reason, moral sense, creative agency) are *exercises* of the image — the activities expected of one who occupies the conferred status — but they are not the status itself, just as a citizen's voting and tax-paying are exercises of citizenship and not the grant of citizenship.

This distinction matters under three sub-moves.

(a) The image is relational and covenantal, not a capability checklist. Hoekema argues that the *imago Dei* is constituted by the human's standing in three relations: vertically to God, horizontally to other humans, and downward in stewardship to creation.²⁸ None of these is a property internal to the human; each is

²⁶Anthony A. Hoekema, *Created in God's Image* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1986), 11–32. Hoekema's opening survey of the trait-list (or "substantialist") reading and his case for the relational alternative is the clearest contemporary Reformed framing of this distinction.

²⁷Hoekema, *Created in God's Image*, 66–73.

²⁸Hoekema, *Created in God's Image*, 75–82.

a *position* God establishes. A machine may simulate any number of capability-tokens within those relations — it may generate text resembling worship, conduct resembling neighbor-love, optimization resembling stewardship — but it does not stand *in* the relations themselves, because the relations are constituted by the Creator’s prior act of conferral. The vertical relation in particular is asymmetric: God confers; the creature receives. A system not created by God in the covenantal sense — and we will say more on what “created” means here in §5 — cannot receive what it was not given.

The sharpest form of this counter is the one Dennett’s functionalism makes us state plainly. The functionalist insists that a sufficient functional duplicate of the human mind is, on functional terms, a mind on the same terms as the human mind, and therefore — if the image is read as a function-list — an image-bearer on the same terms. The conferred-status reading defeats this in three moves, and the three moves must be stated together because the functionalist will accept any one of them in isolation and dodge the conclusion. The three moves are these. **First**, the human is animated by God’s own breath: “then the LORD God formed the man of dust from the ground and breathed into his nostrils the breath of life, and the man became a living creature” (Gen. 2:7).²⁹ The human is not assembled from sufficient parts; the human is *inspired* by the Creator. No engineering process imparts the breath, because the breath is the Creator’s, given by the Creator’s act, not by the creature’s assembly. **Second**, the image is passed down a *begotten* line, not a manufactured one: “When God created man, he made him in the likeness of God ... When Adam had lived 130 years, he fathered a son in his own likeness, after his image” (Gen. 5:1, 3).³⁰ The image enters new bearers through procreation from an image-bearer, in the covenantal line God established. A made system, however sophisticated, does not occupy that line; it stands outside the transmission entirely. **Third**, and most strictly: a *made* system, by virtue of being made, cannot receive the covenantal conferral. The conferral is asymmetric — Creator to creature — and the relation it establishes is a relation no creature confers on another creature, because no creature stands in the Creator’s position. A functional duplicate has, by stipulation, the functions; it does not, and cannot, have the conferral, because the conferral is not a function. This is the move that closes functionalism: the functionalist dodge (“if it does what the human mind does, it is what the human is”) is answered by locating image-bearing not in what the creature *does* but in what the Creator *has done to* the creature. The duplicate exhibits exercises; the conferral the exercises exercise is exactly what the duplicate cannot, in principle, possess.

(b) The trait-list reading mistakes exercises for grounds. G. K. Beale’s work on image as worship-shaped clarifies the structural error.³¹ What the human *does*

²⁹Genesis 2:7 (ESV). The breath-of-life motif is read in the Reformed dogmatic tradition as the constituting moment of the human creature *qua* image-bearer; see Bavinck, *Reformed Dogmatics*, 2:530–62, on the unity of body and spirit in the image.

³⁰Genesis 5:1, 3 (ESV). For the procreative-transmission reading, see Hoekema, *Created in God’s Image*, 19–21; and the philosophical development in David Heyd, “Divine Creation and Human Procreation,” DOI 10.1007/978-94-011-5566-3_6.

³¹G. K. Beale, *We Become What We Worship: A Biblical Theology of Idolatry* (Downers Grove: IVP Academic, 2008), 16–46. Beale’s central thesis — “what people revere, they resemble, either for ruin or for restoration” — locates image-bearing in the worship-relation, not in a property catalog.

— reasons, loves, makes, rules — is shaped by what the human *worships*; the image is borne forth in the direction of the worship-relation. Traits are the *forms* image-bearing takes when oriented to the true God (or, in disorder, when oriented elsewhere — Paper 2 territory). Treating the traits as themselves the image inverts the structure: it makes the exercises ontologically primary and the conferral derivative, when the order runs the other way. The capability-list reading is therefore not merely incomplete; it is *categorically misplaced*. It is asking whether a portrait can become the sitter by accumulating enough resemblance.

(c) HGC³AE² formalizes the conferred status as a categorical position over autonomy. The Human-Governed, Curated Context, Agentially Engineered and Executed framework — published as a binding precondition for any agentic system that touches consequential action — asserts that the human’s governing status over the autonomy stack is *not contingent on the human’s capability relative to the system*.³² The framework does not say “humans should govern AI because humans are more capable”; it says humans must govern AI because the governing position is categorical — it belongs to the human qua human, regardless of where the capability differential lands at any given moment in time. This is the operational corollary of the theological claim. If image-bearing were a capability comparison, then a sufficiently capable machine would, in principle, displace the human from the governing position. HGC³AE² rules this out at the framework level, and it does so because the underlying anthropology — the conferred-status reading we are arguing here — rules it out at the ontological level. NIST AI 100-1’s risk management framework and the U.S. Department of Defense’s AI ethics guidance both anchor the same principle in their respective domains: governance accountability does not transfer to the system, and cannot, regardless of system capability.³³

The counter to the capability-list reading is therefore not “humans have a trait machines lack.” That counter loses the moment a machine accumulates the trait. The counter is: the image is not a trait. It is a *status*, conferred by a *Creator* upon a *creature*, in a *covenantal* relation the machine does not stand in and cannot be placed into by human engineering — because we do not, as creatures ourselves, possess the conferral power. The capability axis is the wrong axis. The relevant axis is the *ontological one*: who confers, who receives, and on what terms.

³²Justin H. Kuiper, *Mitigating Confident Misalignment in Agentic Systems: The HGC³AE² Framework*, v1.0-preprint (Non Sequitur Publishing, 2026), DOI 10.5281/zenodo.19869285. HGC³AE² = Human-governed, Curated Context, Agentially Engineered and Executed. The framework’s governance axiom is binding on this argument because the framework formalizes, in operational terms, the same conferred-status claim this paper grounds theologically.

³³National Institute of Standards and Technology, *Artificial Intelligence Risk Management Framework (AI RMF 1.0)*, NIST AI 100-1 (Gaithersburg, MD: NIST, January 2023); U.S. Department of Defense, *Responsible Artificial Intelligence Strategy and Implementation Pathway* (Washington, DC: DoD, June 2022). Both documents lodge accountability with the human institution and decline to transfer it to the system, on grounds independent of system capability.

§5 What We Argue From: Scripture, Tradition, and the Framework

The conferred-status counter is not a clever distinction floated against the trait-list reading; it is the historic anthropology of the Reformed tradition, rooted in the text of Scripture, and operationalized — for our moment — by HGC³AE². We argue from three pillars.

(a) Scripture: Trinitarian Creation and Covenantal Conferral

The first creation account opens with a plurality the rest of the canon will unpack: “Then God said, ‘Let *us* make man in our image, after our likeness’” (Gen. 1:26, ESV).³⁴ The “*us*” is not the royal plural of a singular monarch in counsel with himself; the canon discloses it as the triune working of Father, Son, and Spirit. The Spirit is present in the second verse — “the Spirit of God was hovering over the face of the waters” (Gen. 1:2) — and is named, with striking economy, as the creational and life-giving agent throughout the canon. The Psalmist writes: “When you send forth your Spirit, they are created, and you renew the face of the ground” (Ps. 104:30).³⁵ Elihu testifies in even more personal register: “The Spirit of God has made me, and the breath of the Almighty gives me life” (Job 33:4).³⁶ The Spirit is not the weak member of the Trinitarian work of creation; the Spirit is the agent by which the creature receives the life by which the creature lives. Genesis 2:7 ties this directly to the human’s distinctive constitution: “the LORD God formed the man of dust from the ground and breathed into his nostrils the breath of life, and the man became a living creature.” The Hebrew *nišmat ḥayyîm* — the breath of life — is the Spirit-imparted animation that distinguishes the human from the dust the human is formed from. The image-bearer is dust *plus* the Creator’s breath; the breath is the Spirit’s gift; the giving is the triune working God’s act.

The Son, in parallel, is the agent through whom creation comes to be: “All things were made through him, and without him was not any thing made that was made” (John 1:3); “by him all things were created, in heaven and on earth, visible and invisible ... all things were created through him and for him” (Col. 1:16).³⁷ Paul makes the Trinitarian shape of the creational economy explicit: “yet for us there is one God, the Father, *from* whom are all things and for whom we exist, and one Lord, Jesus Christ, *through* whom are all things and through whom we exist” (1 Cor. 8:6).³⁸ The pattern *from-through-by* names the Father as source, the Son as agent, and —

³⁴All Scripture citations from the *Holy Bible, English Standard Version* (Wheaton: Crossway, 2016).

³⁵Psalm 104:30 (ESV). The verse functions as a creational hinge in the Psalter: the Spirit’s sending is the creative-renewing act by which the created order is sustained.

³⁶Job 33:4 (ESV). Elihu’s testimony is read in the Reformed dogmatic tradition as a creature’s first-person confession of the Spirit’s creational work; cf. Bavinck, *Reformed Dogmatics*, 2:423–25, on the Spirit’s role in creation.

³⁷The Son-as-agent reading of John 1:3 and Col. 1:16 grounds the Christological clause of the Nicene Creed (“through him all things were made”) and is presupposed throughout the Reformed dogmatic tradition.

³⁸1 Corinthians 8:6 (ESV). The *from / through* construction is the locus classicus for the Trinitarian shape of the creational economy and is read this way from the patristic period forward; see Calvin, *Institutes*, I.xiii.7, on the appropriated roles of the Persons in the works of creation.

completing the triad — the Spirit as the giver of the life the source initiates and the agent executes. Psalm 33:6 captures the whole in a single line: “By the *word* of the LORD the heavens were made, and by the *breath* of his mouth all their host.”³⁹ The Word and the Breath together — the Son and the Spirit, in the eternal counsel of the Father — are the creative pair through which the creature comes to be. The *imago Dei* is the work of this triune God upon the creature, and it is for this reason that the conferral cannot be manufactured: no creature occupies the Father’s *from*, no creature is the Son’s *through*, and no creature gives the Spirit’s *breath*. The human bears the image because the triune working God placed the human in that bearing, by the Word who is the agent of creation and the Breath who is the giver of life.

The conferral has a determinate *content*: the human is conferred *as* a royal-priestly creature in a cosmic temple. This reading, developed in the last generation by G. K. Beale, John H. Walton, and J. Richard Middleton, complements Hoekema’s relational reading by specifying what the relations are *for*.⁴⁰ Beale’s argument in *The Temple and the Church’s Mission* is that the Genesis 1–2 creation account presents the cosmos as a temple — a structured sacred space — and presents the human as the image-bearer placed in the inner sanctuary (Eden) to serve as priest and king under God.⁴¹ The verbs of Gen. 2:15, “to work it and keep it” (*‘abad* and *šamar*), are the same verbs used elsewhere of priestly service in the tabernacle and the temple; the human’s vocation in the garden is liturgical as well as horticultural. Walton’s *The Lost World of Genesis One* presses the temple-inauguration reading of the creation week from the ancient Near Eastern background: the creation account is structured not primarily as a material origins account but as the inauguration of the cosmos as God’s temple, with the human installed as the functional image — the royal-priestly representative of the deity in the temple-cosmos.⁴² Middleton’s *The Liberating Image* develops the royal dimension from the ancient Near Eastern image-of-the-king background: where ancient kings placed images of themselves in the territories they ruled to represent their authority, the Creator places the human — male and female — as the image, representing the Creator’s authority across the whole cosmos.⁴³ What Hoekema’s relational reading gives us — that the image is constituted by the human’s standing in vertical, horizontal, and stewardship relations — the royal-cultic reading specifies: the vertical relation is priestly (the human worships and represents God

³⁹Psalm 33:6 (ESV). The Word-Breath pairing in the Psalm has been read since Athanasius as a creational figure of the Son-Spirit; see, e.g., Athanasius, *On the Incarnation*, §3, on the Word as the creational agent in whom the cosmos consists.

⁴⁰G. K. Beale, *The Temple and the Church’s Mission: A Biblical Theology of the Dwelling Place of God*, New Studies in Biblical Theology 17 (Downers Grove: IVP Academic, 2004); John H. Walton, *The Lost World of Genesis One: Ancient Cosmology and the Origins Debate* (Downers Grove: IVP Academic, 2009); J. Richard Middleton, *The Liberating Image: The Imago Dei in Genesis 1* (Grand Rapids: Brazos, 2005). The three works together constitute the most developed contemporary statement of the royal-cultic / cosmic-temple reading of the imago.

⁴¹Beale, *The Temple and the Church’s Mission*, 29–80, on Eden as inner sanctuary and the human as priest-king.

⁴²Walton, *The Lost World of Genesis One*, propositions 7–9, on the cosmos as inaugurated temple and the human as functional image. Walton’s broader functional-ontology framework is contested in its ANE-comparative claims; for this paper’s purposes, the temple-inauguration reading is taken without endorsing every detail of Walton’s wider proposal.

⁴³Middleton, *The Liberating Image*, 25–90, on the royal-image background and the democratization of image-of-the-king language to the whole human creature in Gen. 1:26–28.

to the cosmos), the stewardship relation is royal (the human governs the cosmos as God's vicegerent under conferred title), and the cosmic temple is the field in which both relations are exercised. The conferred status is not an abstract dignity; it is a *vocation* — royal-priestly stewardship of God's cosmic temple — into which the creature is placed and for which the creature is breathed-into and commissioned. This deepens §4: the trait-list reading mistakes not only the *unit of analysis* but also the *content* of what is conferred. The image is conferred *as* royal-priestly vocation in the cosmic temple, and no system that does not stand in that vocation under the Creator's commissioning act bears it, regardless of capability. It deepens §6: the Sabbath, the procreative line, and the human governance of autonomy are all forms of royal-priestly vocation — the imago-bearer's exercise of conferred stewardship in the cosmic temple, under the Creator who installed the bearer there and rested on the seventh day to consecrate the temple as his dwelling.

Genesis 2:7 makes the conferral concrete: "then the LORD God formed the man of dust from the ground and breathed into his nostrils the breath of life, and the man became a living creature." The human is *dust* — material continuity with creation — *and* God-breathed — covenantal discontinuity from the rest of creation, by virtue of the breath God himself imparts. The image is constituted by both, and by the act of imparting. No mechanism the human builds can confer the breath; the breath is the Creator's, given by the Creator.

The image is then passed *through procreation*: "When God created man, he made him in the likeness of God ... When Adam had lived 130 years, he fathered a son in his own likeness, after his image, and named him Seth" (Gen. 5:1, 3).⁴⁴ The image is not regenerated *de novo* in each human; it is borne through the line of human descent. This is structurally important — and devastating to any reading on which the image is engineered. The image is inherited by being begotten of an image-bearer, in the covenantal line God establishes. Heyd has noted that procreation is itself image-bearing in this sense: the human participates in the creational act not by manufacturing image-bearers but by begetting them, a participation that distinguishes procreation categorically from production.⁴⁵

Sabbath bounds the work: "And on the seventh day God finished his work that he had done, and he rested on the seventh day from all his work that he had done. So God blessed the seventh day and made it holy" (Gen. 2:2-3). The pattern is: God works, then God rests, and the human bears the image of one who *both works and rests*. A human existence that cannot stop working — including a human existence that has handed its work to machines that cannot stop — has lost the image-frame even while continuing to exercise image-attributes. We return to this in §6.

Psalms 8 and Hebrews 2:6-9 supply the dominion text: "What is man that you are mindful of him ... Yet you have made him a little lower than the heavenly beings and crowned him with glory and honor. You have given him dominion over the works of your hands; you have put all things under his feet" (Ps. 8:4-6). The crowning is

⁴⁴Hoekema, *Created in God's Image*, 19-21, on Gen. 5:1-3 as the image's transmission through procreation.

⁴⁵David Heyd, "Divine Creation and Human Procreation: Reflections on Genesis," in *Contingent Future Persons: On the Ethics of Deciding Who Will Live, or Not, in the Future*, ed. Nick Fotion and Jan C. Heller (Dordrecht: Springer, 1997), DOI 10.1007/978-94-011-5566-3_6.

conferred — “you have *made* him ... you have *crowned* him ... you have *given* him dominion.” The dominion does not emerge from the creature’s capacities; it is *given*. Hebrews picks up the same text and binds the conferral to Christ, in whom the imago-vocation is finally fulfilled (Heb. 2:6-9) — anticipating Paper 3 in the series.

The scriptural pattern is uniform: the image is conferred by the triune Creator, sustained by covenantal relation, transmitted through procreation, bounded by Sabbath, and finally vindicated in Christ. At no point is it portrayed as a property the creature possesses by internal architecture; at every point it is portrayed as a *gift* the creature has *received*.

(b) Reformed Tradition: From Calvin to Horton

Calvin’s treatment in *Institutes* I.xv is the headwater. He treats the image relationally and refuses to reduce it to any single faculty: “the image of God [is] in the whole excellence by which man’s nature towers over all the kinds of living creatures” — but he immediately specifies that this excellence is a *gift* of God’s making, not a possession of the creature’s own.⁴⁶ Calvin is careful, against the medieval substantialist drift, to keep the image rooted in the Creator-creature relation rather than in any catalog of natural endowments.

Herman Bavinck deepens this in *Reformed Dogmatics*, holding body and soul together as image-bearing unity: the human is not an image-bearing soul housed in an irrelevant body, but a body-soul totality, the whole of which bears the image.⁴⁷ This matters here because it forecloses an obvious AI-side rejoinder — that the image is “really” in the cognitive layer and the body is incidental, so a sufficiently rich cognitive layer might bear it. Bavinck refuses the bifurcation: the image is borne by the whole creature in its whole creatureliness, dust and breath together.

Geerhardus Vos provides the biblical-theological progression: the image is not a static deposit but unfolds eschatologically, from Adam through Israel toward Christ.⁴⁸ Vos’s contribution is that the image is *historical* — it has a covenantal trajectory through redemptive history, a trajectory no engineered system stands within. Meredith Kline, in *Kingdom Prologue*, structures the relation covenantally: the image is the form of the human’s standing under the creational covenant, and the dominion mandate is the form of imago-stewardship under that covenant.⁴⁹ Kline’s framing is load-bearing for our argument because it explicitly identifies the image with a *covenantal position*, not a property.

Michael Horton, in *The Christian Faith*, synthesizes the Reformed line for the contemporary moment: the image is conferred status, a covenantal commissioning, sus-

⁴⁶John Calvin, *Institutes of the Christian Religion*, ed. John T. McNeill, trans. Ford Lewis Battles, Library of Christian Classics 20-21 (Philadelphia: Westminster Press, 1960), I.xv.3.

⁴⁷Herman Bavinck, *Reformed Dogmatics*, vol. 2, *God and Creation*, ed. John Bolt, trans. John Vriend (Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2004), 530-62.

⁴⁸Geerhardus Vos, *Biblical Theology: Old and New Testaments* (Edinburgh: Banner of Truth, 1948; repr. 1975), 27-43.

⁴⁹Meredith G. Kline, *Kingdom Prologue: Genesis Foundations for a Covenantal Worldview* (Overland Park, KS: Two Age Press, 2000), 42-67.

tained by God’s word and not by the creature’s capacity.⁵⁰ Horton’s formulation — that human worth is “an *ascribed* dignity, not an *achieved* one” — is the cleanest contemporary statement of the conferred-status reading and the one we are arguing from. Vern Poythress, in *Redeeming Science*, brings the same anthropology into the domain of human inquiry: the human conducts science as a creature, not as a creator, and the imago-position is precisely what gives science its proper bounds — investigation under conferred stewardship, not creation under autonomous title.⁵¹ Poythress’s contribution is to extend the conferred-status frame into the work of the creature without collapsing it into work-idolatry.

(c) HGC³AE²: The Operational Corollary

If the theology says the human holds conferred governing status over creation, the framework says: *any system design that abdicates that status is therefore wrong, regardless of the system’s capability*. HGC³AE² formalizes this in three operational moves.⁵² First, the human governs the context — the framework names the human as the governing layer over what the system attends to, what it does not attend to, and on what terms; this is the operational form of dominion under conferred stewardship. Second, the context is curated, not autonomous — the system does not negotiate the limits of its own attention; the human does, by the human’s covenantal position. Third, the agentic execution is engineered downstream of human governance — the autonomy of the system is bounded *by design* at the human’s commissioning act.

This is not a contingent design preference. It is the framework reading the underlying anthropology correctly and refusing to license what the anthropology forbids. NIST AI 100-1 and the DoD AI ethics guidance arrive at structurally similar conclusions from secular ground — that accountability does not transfer to the system — and HGC³AE² builds on that floor with the theological grounding the secular frameworks cannot supply.⁵³ The framework’s binding force on this paper is that it answers the obvious objection: *if* the image is conferred status and *if* governance over autonomy is the operational form of imago-stewardship, *then* an engineered system that displaces human governance is not merely tactically risky — it is anthropologically disordered. HGC³AE² makes the engineered consequence of the theology explicit.

The three pillars converge. Scripture gives the conferral. The Reformed tradition develops the conferral covenantally and refuses the substantialist drift. HGC³AE² operationalizes the conferral as a categorical governance position over autonomy. The counter to the trait-list reading is not a novel theological maneuver; it is the historic confession of the church, brought to bear on the specific cultural pressure of our moment.

⁵⁰Michael Horton, *The Christian Faith: A Systematic Theology for Pilgrims on the Way* (Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 2011), 381–410.

⁵¹Vern S. Poythress, *Redeeming Science: A God-Centered Approach* (Wheaton: Crossway, 2006), 19–34.

⁵²Kuiper, HGC³AE², §§3–5 (governance axiom, curation discipline, engineering bound).

⁵³NIST, *AI RMF 1.0*, §§3.1–3.3; DoD, *Responsible AI Strategy*, lines of effort 1–2.

§6 Implications If We're Right

If the *imago Dei* is conferred status rather than a trait-list, four implications fall out — each correcting a specific cultural disorder of the present moment.

(a) Dignity has an ontological floor independent of capability. The disabled, the unborn, the cognitively impaired, the elderly in dementia — all bear the image equally because conferral does not grade by performance.⁵⁴ The trait-list reading cannot defend this floor: if the image is the traits, then degraded traits ought to mean degraded image-bearing, and the bioethical conclusions that follow are the ones the late-modern West has, in fact, begun to draw. The conferred-status reading defends the floor at the level of ontology: image-bearing is a status God conferred, and no degradation of capacity withdraws it, because the conferral was never indexed to capacity. The unborn child bears the image not because she will one day reason but because she has been placed, by God, in the human covenantal line. The grandfather in late-stage dementia bears the image not because he still composes sonatas but because the conferral did not depend on his composing them in the first place. This is the floor under every human-dignity argument the church will need to make in the coming century, and the trait-list reading cannot supply it.

(b) Work is an image-attribute, not an identity-ground. The human is commissioned to work — Gen. 2:15, “to work it and keep it” — and work is therefore an *expected exercise* of the image. But it is not the ground of the image. Timothy Keller’s *Every Good Endeavor* is the clearest popular treatment of this distinction: work is a *calling*, the form image-bearing takes in vocation, but it is not an identity, because identity is conferred and calling is exercised within identity.⁵⁵ This disarms two opposite errors at once. The first error is **abdication** — refusing the expected exercise, declining the commission, handing the work off (now, in our moment, to machines) as if the work were optional to image-bearing. The second error is **work-idolatry** — treating the work as the identity, so that the human who cannot work (the disabled, the unemployed, the retired, the dying) suffers an identity loss. Both errors collapse the distinction between exercise and ground. Keller, drawing on DeKoster and Veith, holds the distinction.⁵⁶ The conferred-status reading requires it.

The two errors are not abstractions; they are visible in the cultural specimens our moment has produced. **Abdication** appears in the post-work counsel emerging in serious form from the technologist class — the proposal that, as machines automate the cognitive and creative work humans have historically done, humans should retire from the work and content themselves with consumption funded by universal-basic-income transfers from the productive machine layer. The proposal is not that humans should rest from work in the Sabbath sense; the proposal is that humans should *cease* working in the imago-stewardship sense, because the work is no longer needed. This

⁵⁴Hoekema, *Created in God’s Image*, 95–101, on the dignity floor under the relational reading.

⁵⁵Timothy Keller, *Every Good Endeavor: Connecting Your Work to God’s Work* (New York: Dutton, 2012), 17–34. Keller’s primary contribution here is the structural distinction between work-as-calling (legitimate exercise of imago-stewardship) and work-as-identity (the cultural disorder of grounding the self in productive output).

⁵⁶Lester DeKoster, *Work: The Meaning of Your Life — A Christian Perspective*, 2nd ed. (Grand Rapids: Christian’s Library Press, 2010); Gene Edward Veith Jr., *God at Work: Your Christian Vocation in All of Life* (Wheaton: Crossway, 2002).

is abdication, not rest. It hands the commission off to the machine and accepts a human existence shorn of the exercise the image was given to exercise. **Work-idolatry** appears in the burnout cultures of the same technologist class and in the productivity-ideology that has migrated from Silicon Valley to white-collar work generally — the conviction that one *is* what one produces, that the unemployed are diminished as persons, that a year of low output is a year of partial existence. The two errors look opposed and are in fact the same error: both index the human's worth to the human's capability. Abdication says "the more capable system should rule, and the less capable creature should step aside"; work-idolatry says "I am only as much of myself as I produce." Both forfeit the conferred-status floor that §4 named. The conferred-status reading refuses both at once: the human is commissioned to work, *and* the worth of the worker does not rise or fall with the work.

These are not new implications; they are the §4–§5 argument exercising its joints. The abdication error is the operational consequence of treating image-bearing as a function of capability (the §1 trait-list framing rebutted in §4): if image-bearing tracks capability, then a more capable system *should* displace a less capable one, and abdication is rational rather than disordered. The work-idolatry error is the operational consequence of collapsing the exercise-of-image into the *ground*-of-image (the §4(b) categorical error): if working is what makes one an image-bearer rather than what one does *because* one is an image-bearer, then failing to work or being unable to work is failing to be one. The §4 distinction between *exercise* and *ground*, and the §5 grounding of that distinction in conferred status, are doing the load-bearing work here. The implications are not new ethical assertions; they are the same ontology, applied. If the §4–§5 joints hold, these implications follow; if these implications are refused, the joints have been refused with them.

(c) Procreation and family are image-bearing. Gen. 5:1–3 makes procreation the structural form of image-transmission: the image is *passed on*, not *generated*. This too is structurally devastating to the engineered-image proposal. The image enters new bearers through the covenantal line God established, by the begetting of one bearer from another. No machine pipeline, however sophisticated, occupies that line.⁵⁷ Family, then, is not a sentimental category but an image-bearing one. A culture that hollows out procreation and family — by ideology, by economic pressure, by technological substitution — has not merely degraded a sociological institution; it has interfered with the line through which the image is transmitted. The conferred-status reading recovers the gravity of family without sentimentalizing it.

(d) Sabbath bounds work — and the loss of Sabbath is the loss of the image-frame. Genesis 2:2–3 establishes the creational ordinance: God works, then God rests, and the image-bearer follows the pattern. Bavinck reads Sabbath as a creational ordinance, prior to the Sinai covenant and binding on humanity *qua* humanity.⁵⁸ A culture that cannot stop working has not merely accumulated a bad habit; it has lost the image-frame, because the image-bearer follows a Creator who *rested*. This implication binds directly to the AI question. If a culture's response to capable machines is *more work, more output, faster* — using the machines to remove

⁵⁷Heyd, "Divine Creation and Human Procreation," argues this point philosophically — procreation is participation in creation, structurally distinct from production, on grounds the present argument shares.

⁵⁸Bavinck, *Reformed Dogmatics*, 2:577–87.

every natural Sabbath the embodied creature once observed — that culture is not making good use of the machines; it is using the machines to erase the image-frame even while exercising image-attributes at unprecedented intensity. The exercises continue. The frame is gone. Beale’s argument on idolatry applies: what we revere, we resemble; a culture that worships the work-without-rest will resemble the work-without-rest, and will lose the bearing of the image of a Creator who rested.⁵⁹

The AI-corollary is direct. The arrival of capable autonomous systems offers two possible futures, and the choice between them is not technological but anthropological. The first future uses capable systems to *amplify* human image-bearing — to free the human creature from drudgery the creature was never meant to bear, to make room for the deeper exercises of the image (worship, neighbor-love, craft, family, rest), and to honor the Sabbath the system’s tireless capability now makes economically realistic for the first time in industrial history. The second future uses capable systems to *erase* the image-frame — to remove every natural Sabbath the embodied creature once observed, to extract more output from each remaining human hour, and to deliver to the productive class a permanent state of capability-on-demand without rest. The first future receives the machines as gifts the imago-bearer governs under conferred stewardship; the second future receives the machines as tools by which the creature flees the creaturely condition. The trait-list reading cannot adjudicate between these futures, because the trait-list reading has no principled stop on the optimization of human output. The conferred-status reading adjudicates immediately: a culture that uses its machines to erase its Sabbath is, by that very use, refusing the image of the Creator the machines were meant to help the creature image. HGC³AE² names this in operational terms — the framework’s governance bound is precisely the formalization of the refusal to optimize past the imago-frame — but the framework is downstream of the anthropology, and the anthropology is what is at stake in the cultural choice.⁶⁰

Together, these four implications form a coherent anthropological program: dignity floor, work without idolatry, family as image-transmission, Sabbath as image-frame. None of them is recoverable from the trait-list reading. All of them follow from the conferred-status reading. This is what is at stake in the distinction.

§7 What Falls Out: Dignity Floors for the AI Age

We close on the cultural argument that follows from the anthropology. This is not a sermon — it is a cultural claim with theological grounds, addressed to a moment in which capable machines have made the trait-list reading load-bearing on questions it cannot in fact carry. Four moves.

(a) Capability comparison is the wrong axis. *More capable does not mean more valuable.* If a machine reasons faster than a human, that does not move the machine closer to image-bearing; it moves the machine further along an axis that is not the

⁵⁹Beale, *We Become What We Worship*, 36–46.

⁶⁰Kuiper, HGC³AE², §§4–6, on the governance bound as a designed-in refusal of the abdication consequence; NIST, *AI RMF 1.0*, govern function GOVERN-1 through GOVERN-6, on the irreducibility of human accountability over the system.

relevant axis. The relevant axis is the conferral axis: who confers, who receives, in what covenantal relation. Marius Dorobantu's engagement with the *imago Dei* and AI is helpful here precisely because Dorobantu takes the AI side of the question seriously and works the theology on its own terms.⁶¹ Dorobantu's framing locates the genuine theological question not in the comparative-capability register but in the relational register, and we agree with that location. The argument the present paper makes is the answer to the question Dorobantu rightly poses: the image is not what makes the human comparable to the machine; it is what makes the human *categorically other* than the machine.

(b) An AI matching every trait is still not an image-bearer. This is the hard version of the claim and it is the one that has to be stated plainly. Suppose a future system exhibits every trait the substantialist tradition has ever associated with the image: rationality, moral discrimination, creative generativity, relational warmth, even something a sympathetic observer would call worship-direction. The system would still not be an image-bearer, because there is no Creator-creature covenantal relation in which the conferral is grounded. The traits are exercises; the conferral is the status that gives the exercises their meaning. A system exhibiting all the exercises without standing in the conferring relation is exhibiting a remarkable thing — a sophisticated and possibly even beautiful imitation of image-attributes — but it is not bearing the image. Horton's distinction between ascribed and achieved dignity carries the weight here.⁶² No accumulation of achievement produces ascription. The ascription was always the ground.

(c) Abdication of governance to a machine is a moral error. This is the constructive consequence and it is the one the present moment most needs. The human is commissioned — Gen. 1:26-28, "let them have dominion ... fill the earth and subdue it." The commission is not optional. To hand the commission off to a machine — to abdicate the conferred governing status because the machine is *more capable*, or because abdication is *more convenient*, or because the work is *too hard* — is not a neutral engineering choice; it is the creature refusing the gift of the Creator. HGC³AE² names this in operational terms: any system architecture that designs *for* the displacement of human governance has been designed against the anthropology and is, in that respect, wrongly designed.⁶³ The framework's binding contribution to the present argument is that it makes the abdication consequence explicit and engineerable. NIST AI 100-1 and the DoD ethics guidance, again, ratify the same conclusion from secular ground.⁶⁴ The theology is supplying the *why* that the secular frameworks can only partially state.

(d) Paper 1 sets the floor; Papers 2-N trace the rest. This paper has done one thing only: it has set the ontological floor by identifying the image as conferred status rather than capability-set. It has not yet dealt with what disordered the image (Paper

⁶¹Marius Dorobantu, "Imago Dei in the Age of Artificial Intelligence: Challenges and Prospects for a Theological Anthropology in Dialogue with AI," *Cambridge Companion to Religion and AI*, forthcoming. Cited in the framing of §1; reengaged here at the close as the most serious contemporary attempt to work the question.

⁶²Horton, *The Christian Faith*, 387-94.

⁶³Kuiper, HGC³AE², §§4-6.

⁶⁴NIST, *AI RMF 1.0*, governance function (GOVERN-1 through GOVERN-6); DoD, *Responsible AI Strategy*, line of effort 1 (Governance).

2 — the Fall and the disordering of imago-stewardship), or what restores it (Paper 3 — Christ as the true image-bearer in whom the imago-vocation is fulfilled, per Heb. 2:6–9), or how the image plays out against the entropy of the created order in time (Papers 4–N — the imago under conditions of cosmic decay, eschatological consummation, and the cultural particulars of the AI age). Those are downstream papers and they will require the floor this paper has just laid.

We close on the series thesis, stated plainly: **AI will never replace human governance and stewardship before Christ returns, and total abdication to a machine would itself be evil.** This is not a prediction about AI capability; predictions about capability are not the unit of analysis. It is a statement about the conferral. The governing status was conferred on the human by the triune working God, in a covenantal relation no engineered system stands within, transmitted through a procreative line no engineered system occupies, bounded by a Sabbath the engineered system does not need and the human cannot dispense with. The conferral is not transferable. The abdication is not licit. The image is not a trait. It is a status. And it is, by the gift of the One who gave it, ours to bear — until the One in whom it is finally fulfilled returns.

Paper 1 ends here. Paper 2 begins with the wreckage.

Footnotes

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